

Soft Trump voters: a fast ad program for the last five weeks

Whit Pendergast, Hoplight. September 23, 2026, for donor and experiment advisers.

One in five 2024 Trump voters now regret their vote. The Iran war and rising costs top their reasons (Navigator Research, September 2026), and almost nobody is talking to them about it inside their own values or in a voice they would trust. Low-cost static and motion ads on Meta, from a neutral or right-of-center name, on the Epstein files and the Iran war, through November 3. A randomized message test first, then a held-out slice of the voter list so the effect on enthusiasm and turnout can be measured.

THREE PROGRAM SIZES

\$35K

Message test only

2024 Trump voters. Ten days. No vehicle needed.

Survey test vendor	\$24K
Test creative	\$3K
Hoplight	\$8K
Total	\$35K

\$180K

Test, then one state

Four weeks of ads. About 800,000 people reached.

Ads on Meta	\$95K
Message test	\$24K
In-field measurement	\$25K
Creative, at cost	\$9K
Hoplight	\$27K
Total	\$180K

\$475K

Test, then four states

Each with its own holdout. About 3 million people.

Ads on Meta	\$340K
Message test	\$24K
In-field measurement	\$50K
Creative, at cost	\$16K
Hoplight	\$45K
Total	\$475K

TIMELINE

On a yes

Message test goes to field.
Results in about ten days.

By Oct 1

Funding and vehicle in place.
That buys four weeks of live ads.

Oct 5 to 26

Ads live, three weekly rounds.
Money moves to what works.
Every variant loaded before Meta's cutoff, about Oct 27.

Oct 27 to Nov 3

Winners run. Results memo by mid-November.

WHAT IT NEEDS BESIDES MONEY

An existing C4 or PAC with a neutral or right-of-center brand, Meta's political ad approval already in hand, and an ad account with spending history. Its counsel clears each ad. Hoplight runs the campaign and does not own the vehicle.

OPEN CHOICES FOR ADVISERS

Where. One Senate state, or a set of close House districts.

Measurement. Held-out areas with a short survey, or person-level randomization if the vehicle already texts.

Vehicle type. A C4 while ads name only Trump and the issues. Naming a 2026 candidate moves it to a PAC.

A third issue. Rising costs adds two test arms, about \$6K to \$12K.

Added channels. Volunteer sharing and image texts ride on the same creative.

WHY HOPLIGHT

81 from 56

Republicans, officer pay

The staff-written message reached 70.

71 from 55

Religious conservatives, union support

The staff-written message took it down to 51. Enterprising conservatives rose 26 points on pay.

66 from 44

2024 non-voters, officer pay

Union support 46 to 57. The staff-written message dropped it to 36.

Randomized trial of 3,006 US adults, August 2025: two messages from Hoplight's message generation tool against a placebo and an existing campaign's persuasion message. Separately, close to \$1 million of Meta ads for a commercial activist brand Whit co-founded, including ten months of Epstein-themed creative: 6.5 million views, Meta's review let it through when it implied, people stopped for it like anything else on the account, and the clicks cost 18 percent less.